Real Lives™
User’s Guide

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Chapter 1. Introduction to Real Lives

What is Real Lives and why is it a valuable learning tool for my students?

Real Lives is an interactive life simulation that enables students to live one of billions of lives in any country in the world while gaining real-world practice in reasoning, problem-solving, critical thinking, and compromise, as well as a sense of personal responsibility. When students are "born" into another country and are faced with representations of real-life events and problems, they must make decisions and witness consequences. They learn about the world and gain an increased appreciation of their own culture as they learn about the cultures of other peoples.

Real Lives promotes deductive and inferential reasoning through critical thinking and problem solving. Students must observe, predict, compare and contrast information, identify variables, and choose between relevant and irrelevant data. They are constantly engaged in such higher-order thinking tasks as analysis, synthesis, and evaluation. Students are challenged by overt as well as subtle problems that must be resolved before they can proceed. They must constantly weigh variables and ask, "How can I resolve this problem or set of problems by taking into account all of the factors I've just learned?" "Where can I find the information I need to make these decisions?"

Real Lives uses statistically accurate events to bring to life different cultures, political and economic systems, personal attributes, health issues, family issues, schooling, jobs, religions, geography, wars, and more. The computer manipulates the data behind the scenes in order to show how the world is likely to behave under a variety of conditions. However, it is the students who drive the simulation, because they are responsible for interpreting the data and selecting among alternative actions.

As an added feature, unlike real life, students can relive an experience so that they can learn from it. Students always have the option of replaying a simulation (or moving back in time to a younger age) so that they can learn can learn why things went wrong and how their actions or decisions influenced events. Instead of just accepting a loss or replaying past failures, students can think about the steps they might have taken to achieve a more desirable outcome. How might they have responded differently when faced with an unexpected job loss, medical emergency, or a human rights violation? What information were they missing to help them make a clear decision the first time around? Where could they find that information next time?

The Real Lives software, carefully selected Internet links, and supplemental classroom activities provide for a multidimensional and multidisciplinary learning environment to motivate students.

Chapter 2. Getting Started

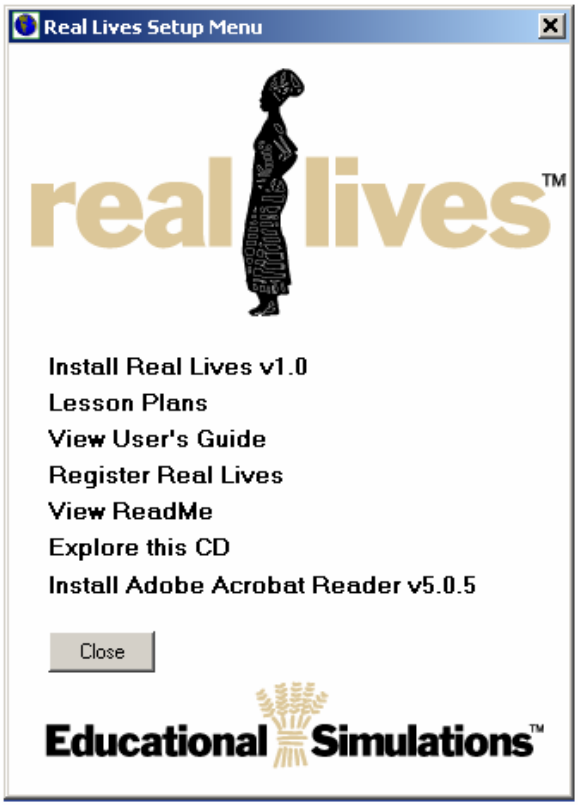
System Requirements

Windows 95 or higher or equivalent Macintosh running Virtual PC
PC with Pentium 100 or higher CPU
150MB free hard drive space
32 Megabytes of RAM (64 MB or more recommended)
16 bit color or higher
1024 by 768 resolution (recommended)

Installation Instructions

Administrator rights are required for installation on Windows NT, 2000, and XP.

To install Real Lives, place the Real Lives CD into the system CD-ROM drive, and the following screen will appear. Choose what you want to do by clicking on the text commands. If the screen fails to appear, run RLSetup.exe from your CDROM drive.



Install Real Lives 1.0
Initiates the setup process.

Lesson Plans
Opens the Real Lives Lesson Plans folder.

View User's Guide
Opens the Real Lives User's guide.

Register Real Lives
Initiates the registration process.

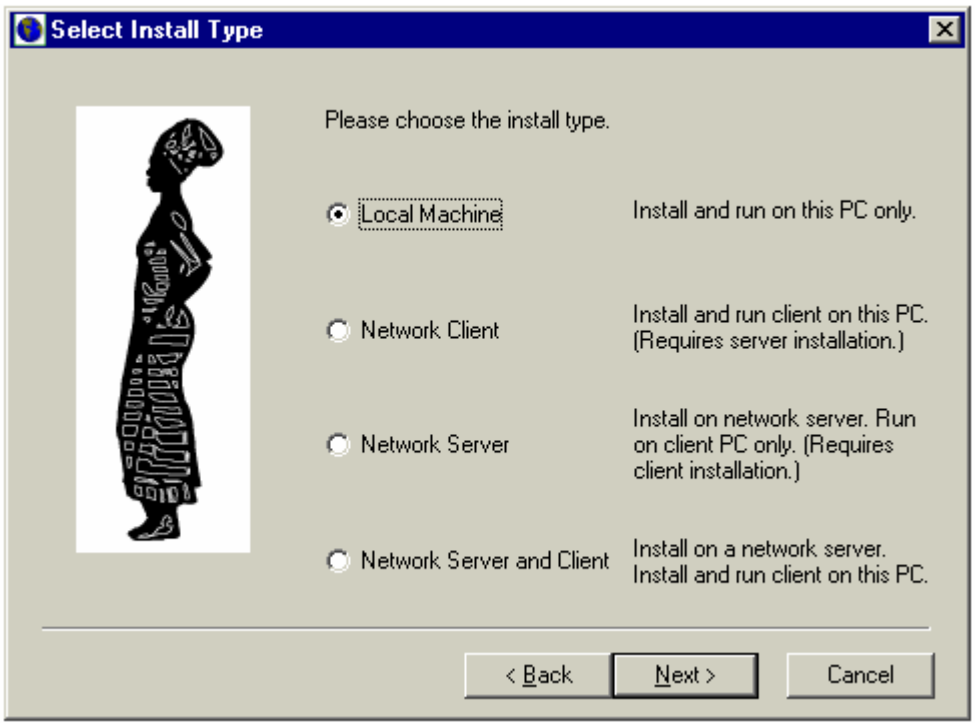
View Read Me
Opens the Read Me text document.

Explore this CD
Opens the CD in Windows Explorer.

Install Adobe Acrobat Reader v5.0.5
Installs Acrobat Reader to allow viewing of .PDF files.

You will be asked to enter a license key during the setup process. This is found on the inside front cover of your product binder. An invalid key or a key of all zeros will offer to install the evaluation version. If your license key is for a single license, simply follow the directions on the screen.

If your license key is for a site license, you will see the following screen:



Option 1: Install and Run on this PC only. This installs Real Lives for use as a single user on one PC, without any network connection necessary. Most users will use this option.

Option 2: Network Client. This installs the client side of Real Lives. For this installation, you need to know the name and location of the Network Folder in which Real Lives is installed. Examples:

Example 1
Name and location of Real Lives server installation specified by computer name and folder:

*networkcomputer**reallivesfolder*

where

networkcomputer is the name of the computer on which Real Lives server installation is installed and

reallivesfolder is the name of the folder in which Real Lives server is installed.

Note: You must have read/write access to *reallivesfolder*.

Example 2
Name and location of Real Lives server installation specified by drive letter and path:

n:\reallivesfolder

where

n:\reallivesfolder is the drive letter and path to the folder in which Real Lives server installation is installed.

Note: You must have read/write access to *reallivesfolder*.

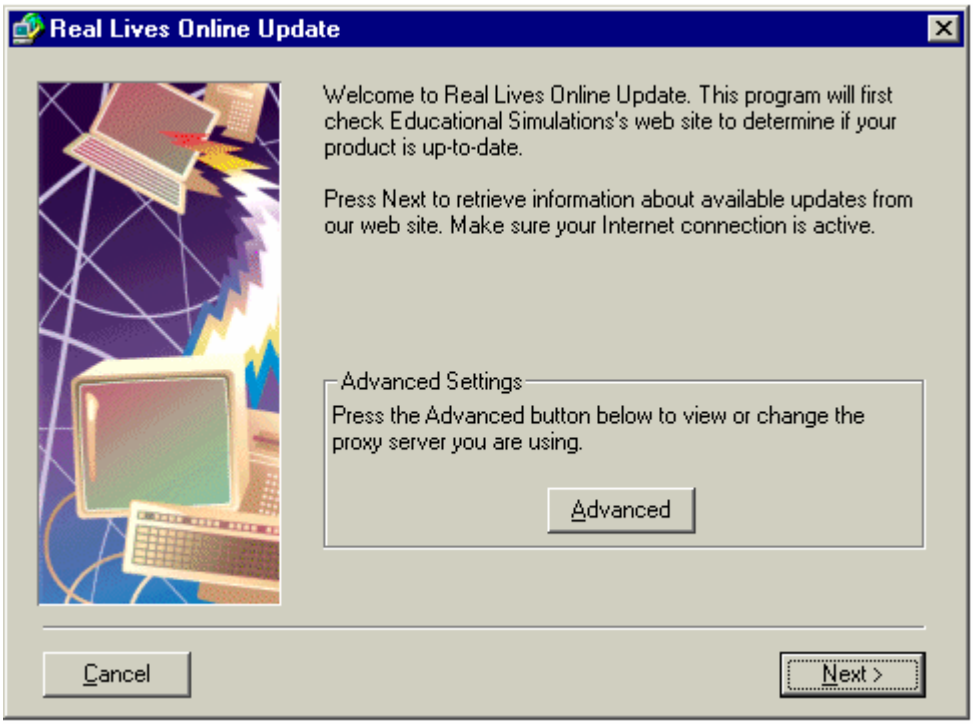
Option 3: Network Server. This installation will install Real Lives on a file server or in a shared folder. Client installations are done separately according to Option 2 above. You must provide the name and location of the Network Folder in which you install Real Lives to users installing the Network Client. Network clients must have read/write access to the Network Folder.

Option 4: Network Server and Client installation. This installation option will install Real Lives client and server files on a single computer. You need to know the name and location of the Network Folder in which the Real Lives will be installed. You will also need to know the name and location of the server folder where the Real Lives server installation will be installed. Follow the directions in Option 2 for the client installation. Follow the directions in Option 3 for the server installation.

Note: You must have read/write access to *reallivesfolder*.

During installation, you will be asked if you want to register Real Lives. Registered users receive free, unlimited technical support via e-mail and can choose to receive update notices and new product announcements. You will have a choice to either send the information via the Internet or to create a file to mail or fax to Educational Simulations.

During installation, you will be asked if you want to check for Real Lives updates, available from the web. Follow the directions on this screen.



If you want to check for updates periodically when Windows starts, click "Advanced" and set the day interval to the desired frequency. If you do not want to check for updates periodically, set the interval to zero to turn it off.

Note: If you have a Real Lives Evaluation installed, please uninstall it before you install the commercial version.

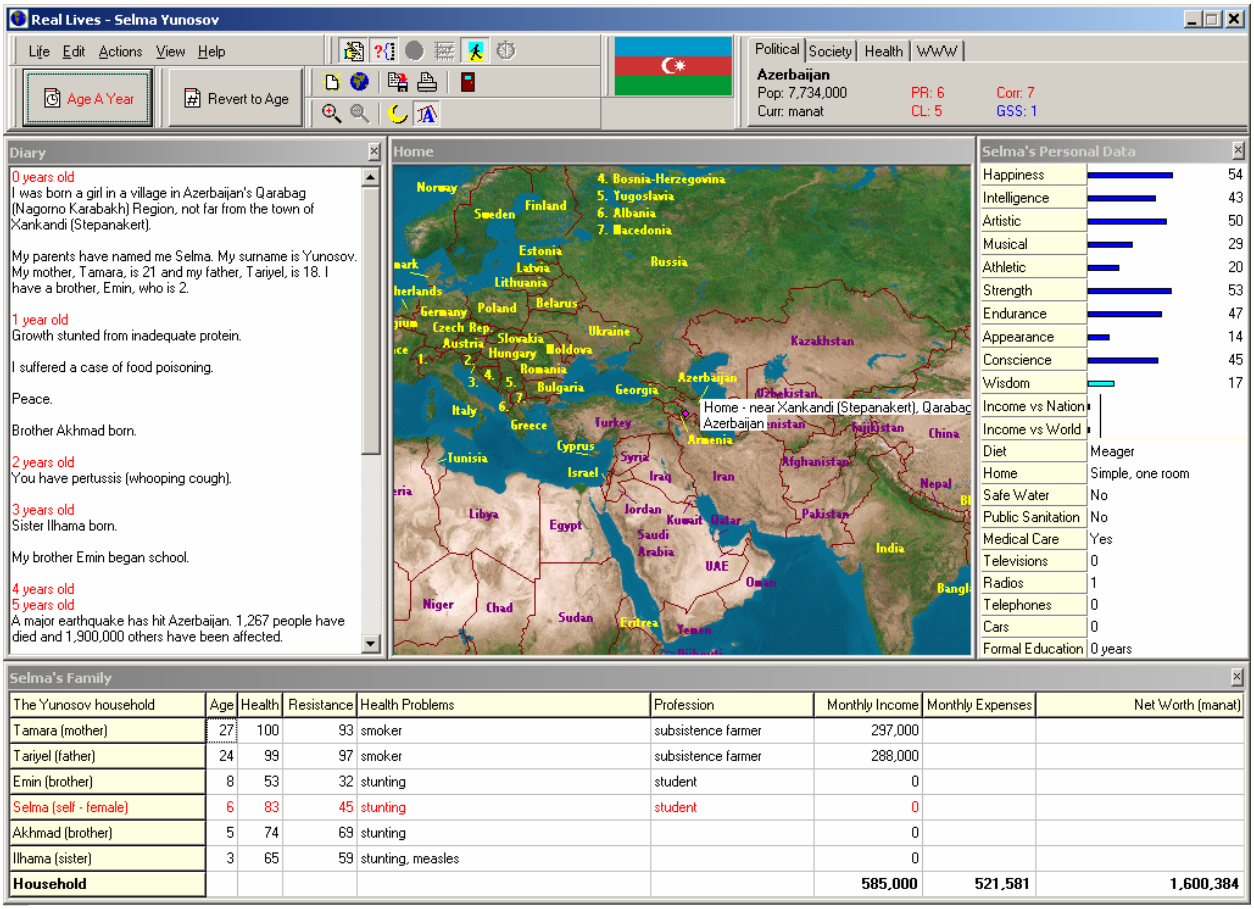
Where to Get Support

Real Lives support is available through our web site, http://www.educationalsimulations.com or by calling 888-832-1500.

Chapter 3. Using Real Lives

Start Real Lives by clicking the Start button on your Windows system and selecting Real Lives from the Programs menu. When the application starts, you will see an information box, which provides the name and gender of your character, as well as the location where your character was born. When you click "OK" you'll see the main Real Lives Interface. Its elements are explained below. Move your character through the simulation by clicking the "Age A Year" button in the upper left corner of the application.

User Interface

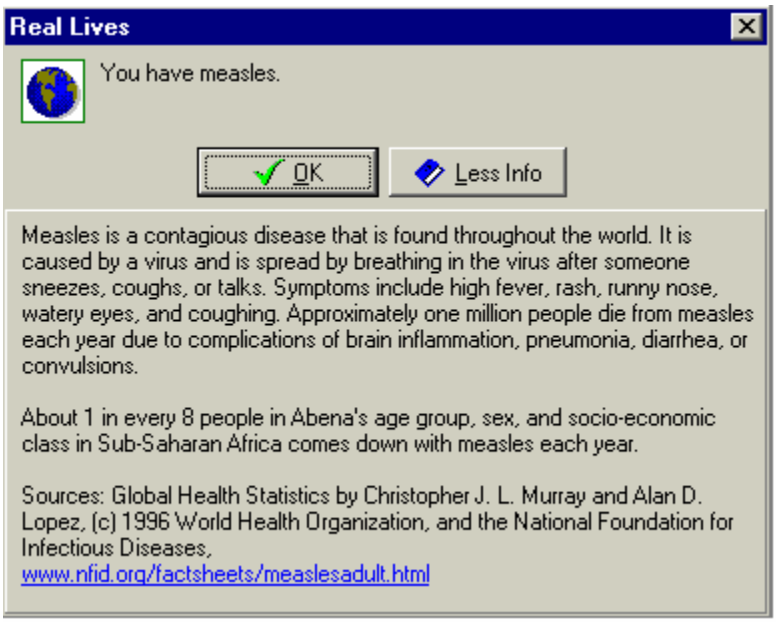


The Yunosov household	Age	Health	Resistance	Health Problems	Profession	Monthly Income	Monthly Expenses	Net Worth (manat)
Tamara (mother)	27	100	93	smoker	subsistence farmer	297,000		
Tariyel (father)	24	99	97	smoker	subsistence farmer	288,000		
Emin (brother)	8	53	32	stunting	student	0		
Selma (self - female)	6	83	45	stunting	student	0		
Akhmad (brother)	5	74	69	stunting		0		
Ilhama (sister)	3	65	59	stunting, measles		0		
Household						**585,000**	**521,581**	**1,600,384**

Configure Issues Window

The Configure Issues Window is accessed from the Life menu. Each configurable issue can be checked or unchecked. By default, each item is checked and used by Real Lives. If you do not want Real Lives to consider an issue during a simulation, uncheck it here.

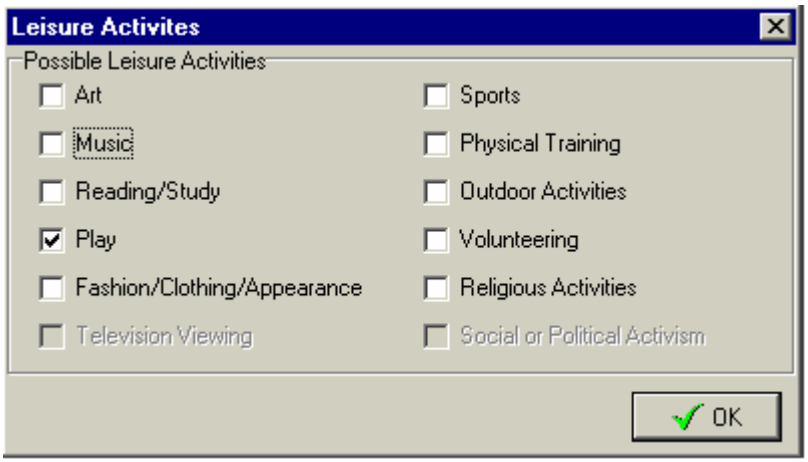
Information Boxes



Information boxes, like the one shown above, provide information about the country and circumstances in which your character is living. Click "Learn more" for additional information.

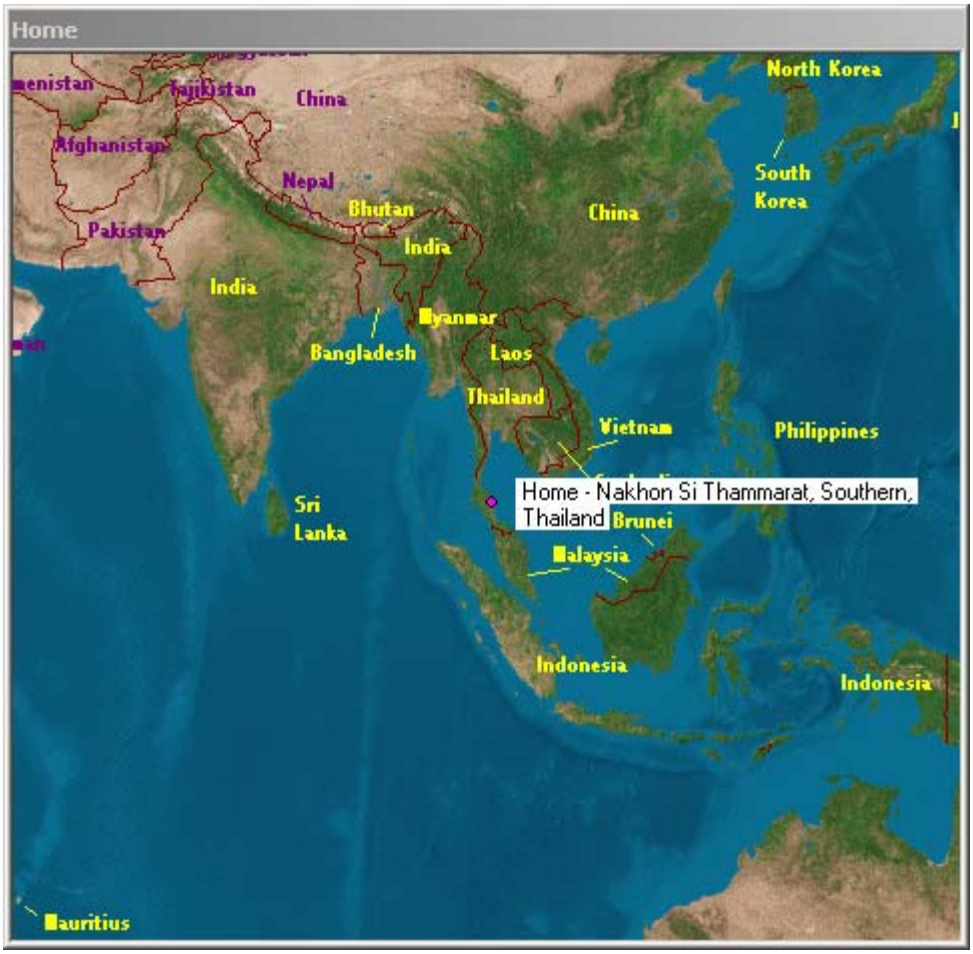
Most information boxes give the source of the information, and some boxes include an Internet link to the source.

Decision Boxes



As your character ages, you will be presented with many opportunities to make choices for your character. In the example above, the character is being asked to choose how leisure time will be spent. These choices will help determine what happens through the entire life of a character. For example, a character that chooses "Sports" is more likely to be healthy for a long period of time than one who does not. However, just as in real life, Real Lives offers no guarantees.

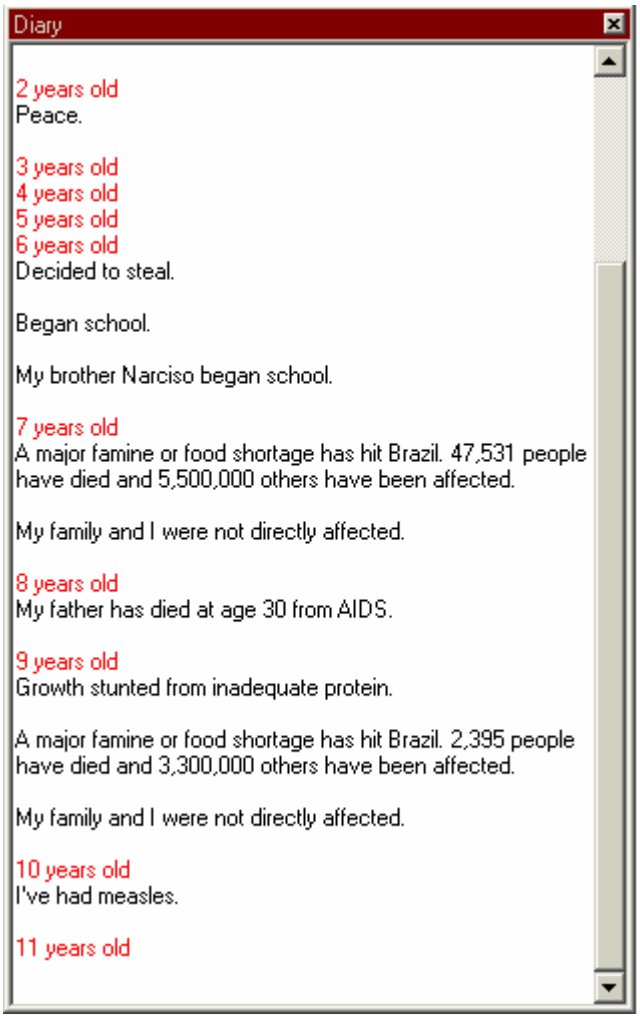
Map Window



The center of the screen is a map showing the characters location. The map can be zoomed in and out to a maximum resolution of 4 kilometers per pixel, and both day and night views are available. The map is generated by satellite photography and is an accurate depiction of Earth's color and geography. The day view gives the user information about local vegetation and terrain and the night view shows lights of industrialized and populated areas.

- Use the CN Toggle icon to view country borders and names in the day view or city names in the night view.
- For a closer view of the map—select Zoom In from the View menu or click the Zoom In icon on the top of the screen.
- For a more distant view of the map—select Zoom Out from the View menu or click the Zoom Out icon on the top of the screen.
- To change from a day to night view (and vice-versa)—click the Toggle Day and Night icon on the top of the screen.

Diary Window



The left side of the screen is a character's diary. The diary records the important events in a character's life. It can be saved, printed or emailed.

- To save the Diary—select Save or Save As from the Life menu or click the Save icon on the top of the screen.
- To print the Diary—select Print from the Life menu or click the Print icon on the top of the screen.
- To e-mail the Diary—select the saved file. Cut and paste the text into the body of an email application, or attach the saved file to an email message.

Family Window

The bottom of the screen displays a matrix of the character's family and some information about each family member.

Evelina's Household								
The Shkadova household	Age	Health	Resistance	Health Problems	Profession	Monthly Income	Monthly Expenses	Net Worth (rubles)
Timofei (father)	28	87	85		blacksmith	16,300		
Tamara (mother)	26	94	96		domestic chores			
Evelina (self - female)	0	26	20					
Household						**16,300**	**26,677**	**602,371**

Shown are:
All family members and their position in the family (Father, mother, sister, brother)

Age
Shown in years.

Health
Shown on a scale of 1 to 100, where 1 is barely alive and 100 is perfect health.

Resistance
Shown on a scale of 1 to 100, this is a measure of the characters resistance to disease.

Health Problems
This lists the specific diseases or health problems for each character.

Profession
Displays the character's job. This field can be empty if the character has no job.

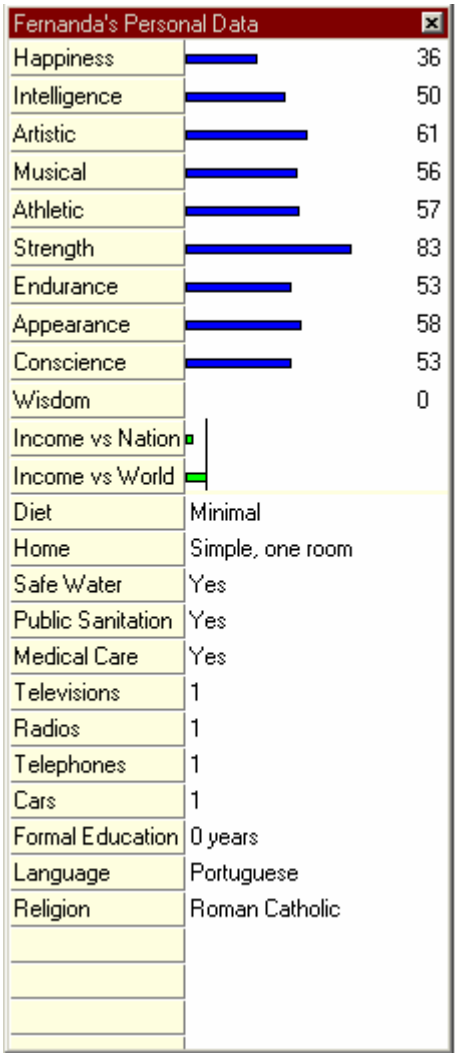
Monthly Income
Displays the monthly income in local currency.

Monthly Expenses
Displays the monthly expenses in local currency.

Net Worth
Displays the value of all assets minus liabilities in local currency.

For those items displayed in currency, move the mouse over the amount, and the value will be displayed in US dollars.

Personal Data Window



Personal Characteristics Data
The right side of the screen contains a list of personal characteristics. These include:

- Happiness
- Intelligence
- Artistic
- Musical
- Athletic
- Strength
- Endurance
- Appearance
- Conscience
- Wisdom

Personal characteristics are those of the character whose life is being simulated. Ratings range from zero to 100 and are initially derived from both random and calculated factors. A character's high intelligence will tend to influence his or her musical and artistic abilities, while someone with low strength will also tend to be less athletic. Similarity between family members shows the effects of heredity.

Income versus Nation and Income versus World
These characteristics show the family's income. A vertical line represents the averages for the nation and world respectively. Some incomes can go off the chart. In these cases a multiplication factor indicates the degree to which the income has exceeded the displayable size.

Diet
This shows the type of diet the family currently enjoys. The diet reflects the level of wealth or poverty for the family. As characters age, they begin to take action to influence their diets. The range of diets is expressed as follows:

- Starvation
- Subsistence
- Meager
- Minimal
- Adequate
- Ample
- Lavish
- Gourmand

Diet has an influence on a character's health, which in turn influences many aspects of the character's life.

Shelter
This shows the type of shelter the family currently enjoys. The type of shelter reflects the level of wealth or poverty for the family. As characters age, they begin to take action to influence the conditions in which they live. The range of shelter options is expressed as follows:

- Homeless
- Makeshift temporary
- Simple, one room
- Simple
- Modest
- Moderate
- Ample
- Luxurious

Access to adequate shelter is a fundamental human need. Shelter can positively or negatively affect a character's health and happiness.

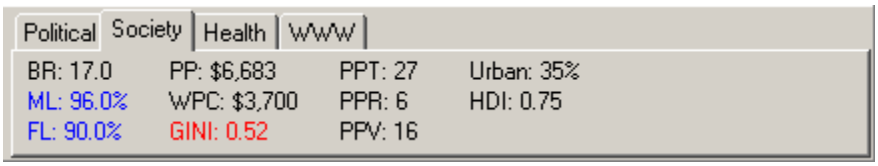
Additional Characteristics

- **Safe Water** - Does this family have access to safe water? (Yes/No)
- **Public Sanitation** - Does this family have access to public sanitation? (Yes/No)
- **Medical Care** - Does this family have access to modern health care? (Yes/No)
- **Televisions** - How many televisions are in this family's home? (Numeric Value)
- **Radios** - How many radios are in this family's home? (Numeric Value)
- **Telephones** - How many telephones are in this family's home? (Numeric Value)
- **Cars** - How many cars does this family own? (Numeric Value)
- **Formal Education** - How many years of education does this character have? (Numeric Value)
- **Language** - What is this family's first language?
- **Religion** - What is the family's religion?

These characteristics reflect statistics from the character's country and vary from character to character depending on location within the country, wealth, random chance and other factors.

Country Information Tabs

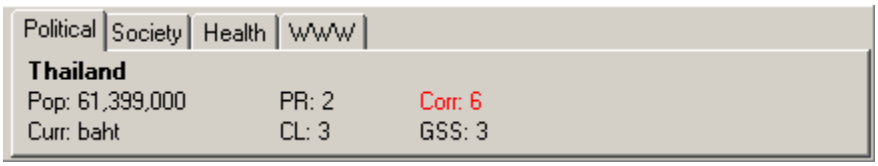
In the upper right corner of the screen, you will find 4 tabs labeled: Society, Political, WWW and Health. Each tab contains information about the country in which your character lives. By hovering the mouse over any of the statistics offered, a short definition and source will appear for each piece of information. These abbreviations are also defined here:



Society

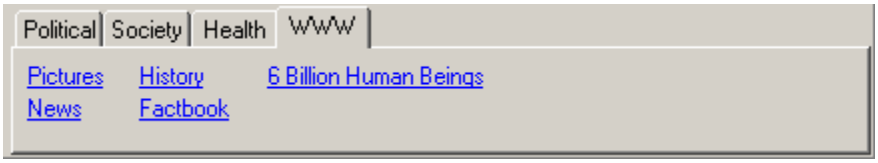
- **BR** - Birthrate. This is the number of live births per thousand people per year.
- **ML** - Male Literacy. The percentage of adult men who know how to read.

- **FL** - Female Literacy. The percentage of adult women who know how to read.
- **PP** - Purchasing Power. The average purchasing power is Gross National Product (GNP) per capita in U.S. Dollars, adjusted for the cost of living. The formula for this is, GNP divided by population times cost of living (COL) divided by US cost of living (USCOL), or GNP/POP X US COL/COL.
- **WPC** - Wealth per Capita. This field measures the country's total wealth divided by the population.
- **GINI** - GINI Index. The GINI index is a measure of income inequality. On a scale of 0 to 1, the inequality of income for each country. A GINI index of zero would indicate complete equality of income. A GINI index of 1.0 would indicate that one person had all of the country's income. GINI indexes range from about 0.15 to 0.65.



Political

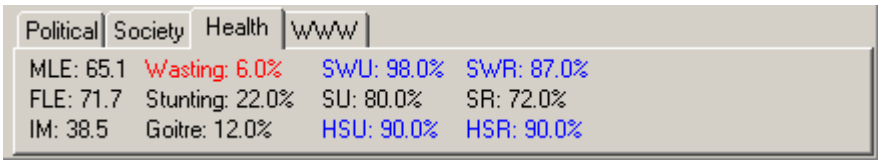
- **Pop** - Population. This is the country's 2001 estimated population.
- **Curr** - Currency. The name of the currency used in the country.
- **PR** - Political Rights. On a scale of 1 to 7, the ability of citizens to affect government. A rating of 1 shows an abundance and a rating of 7 shows a lack of political rights.
- **CL** - Civil Liberties. On a scale of 1 to 7, Freedom from government intervention in an individual's activities. A rating of 1 shows an abundance of and a rating of 7 shows a lack of civil liberties.
- **Corr** - Corruption. On a scale of 1 to 7, the Corruption Perception Index. A rating of 1 shows an apparent lack of corruption, while a rating of 7 shows abundant corruption. The CPI is a composite of polls. Drawing on surveys from independent institutions, it reflects the perceptions of academics, business people and country analysts.
- **GSS** - Government Social Services. On a scale of 1 to 7, the quality and availability of government social services. A rating of 1 represents an abundance of social services, and a rating of 7 indicates a complete lack. GSS is a function of HDI and PPP.



WWW

- **Pictures** – Connects to http://www.picturesoftheworld.com. A web site featuring pictures from around the world.
- **News** – Connects to http://www.oneworld.net. Current news of local events for most countries can be found here.
- **History** – Connects to http://www.encyclopedia.com. Features information about each country.
- **Factbook** – Connects to *The World Factbook* at http://www.cia.gov, the CIA factbook for nations around the world.

- **6 Billion Human Beings** – Connects to http://www.popexpo.net. This site discusses world population issues.



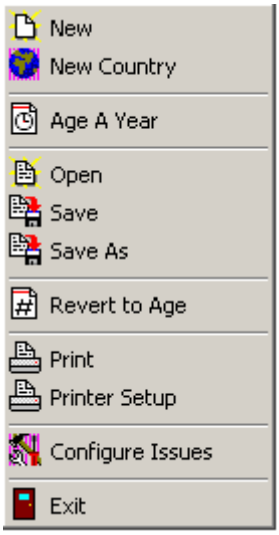
Health

- MLE - Male Life Expectancy. In Years.
- FLE - Female Life Expectancy. In Years.
- IM - Infant Mortality. Mortality per thousand births.
- Wasting - Percentage of population losing muscle mass from inadequate food.
- Stunting - Percentage of population with stunted growth from inadequate protein.
- Goiter - Percentage of population with Goiter from inadequate iodine.
- SWU - Safe Water Urban. Percentage of urban population with access to safe water.
- SU - Sanitation Urban. Percentage of urban population with access to sanitation.
- HSU - Health Services Urban. Percentage of urban population with access to modern health care,
- SWR - Safe Water Rural. Percentage of rural population with access to safe water
- SR - Sanitation Rural. Percentage of rural population with access to sanitation
- HSR - Health Services Rural. Percentages of rural population with access to modern health care

Menu Items

Real Lives offers the following menu items and toolbar buttons. Items showing an icon button are accessible from both the described menu and from a button.

Life Menu



New
Use this command to start a new life. The country is selected randomly, based on birthrates in different countries.

New Country
Use this command to start a new life in a new country. The country is selected from the list of countries presented.

Age a Year
Use this command to move through a life simulation. This is the basic mechanism for moving through the Real Lives program.

Open
Use this command to open a saved life.

Save
Use this command to save a current simulation. If you save and close your simulation, you will not be able to revert to an age earlier than the saved age.

Save As
Same as the Save feature.

Revert to Age
Use this command to revert to any age from 0 to your current age. You can change decisions you made earlier in your life and experience different outcomes. For saved lives, you can only revert to the character's first saved age.

Print
Use this command to print the character's diary.

Printer Setup
Use this command to set the printing options.

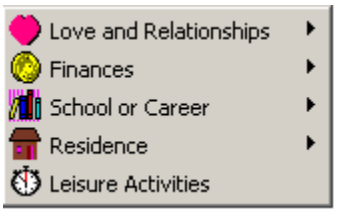
Configure Issues
Use this command to access the Configure Issues window. To learn more about the Configure Issues window, please see Chapter 3, "Configure Issues Window".

Exit
Use this command to exit the application.

Edit Menu

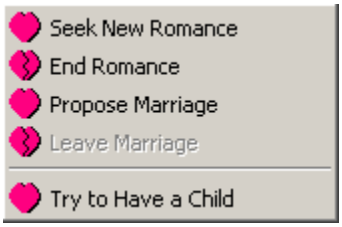
Copy
The Copy command allows users to copy text from fields and from the diary. Copy the text and paste it to an outside application.

Actions Menu



Through this menu, characters actions are invoked and controlled. The features are briefly explained here, but users should spend some time trying each option.

Love and Relationships



Seek New Romance
Use this command to seek a new romantic relationship. When a character reaches his or her teenage years, he or she can become interested in romantic relationships. Romantic relationships are more likely to succeed when a character's personal attributes are closely aligned to those of the potential romantic partner.

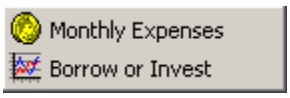
End Romance
Use this command to break off a romantic relationship. You decide when the time is right.

Propose Marriage
Use this command to propose marriage. Your romantic partner may or may not accept your proposal.

Leave Marriage
Use this command to leave your marriage.

Try to Have a Child
Use this command to try to have a child in your romantic relationship or marriage. Having children requires sacrifice and responsibility.

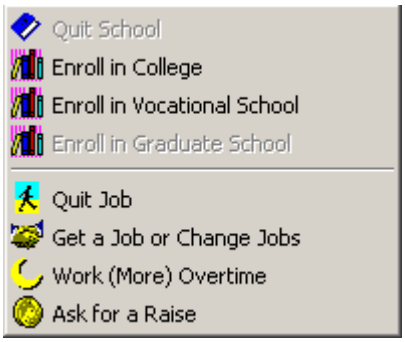
Finances



Monthly Expenses
Use this command to change your monthly expenses. These include expenses related to diet, housing, consumer spending and charitable giving. When you change your character's spending, those changes impact things that happen later in life. For example, if your character improves his or her diet, it is likely that their health will improve.

Borrow or Invest
Use this command to manage financial aspects of your character's life. You may take a loan, or invest money you have earned. A variety of loans and investment options are available, and users should try all of these options to understand the impacts of their actions.

School or Career



Quit School
Use this command to leave school. When you leave school, you will have more time for other things, including leisure activities and working.

Enroll in College
Use this command to try to enroll in college. Not every character has the opportunity to attend college.

Enroll in Graduate School
Use this command to try to enroll in graduate school. Not every character has the opportunity to attend graduate school.

Enroll in Vocational School
Use this command to try to enroll in vocational school. Not every character has the opportunity to attend vocational school.

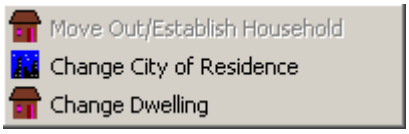
Quit Job
Use this command to leave your employment.

Get a Job or Change Jobs
Use this command to find a job or change jobs. Your job opportunities are determined by the opportunities available in your country, by your personal attributes, your level of education and an element of random chance.

Work (More) Overtime
Use this command to try to earn more money at your current job. If you are working overtime, you will have more money, but less time for other things.

Ask for a Raise
Use this command to ask for a raise. It is not likely that you will get a raise every time you ask.

Residence

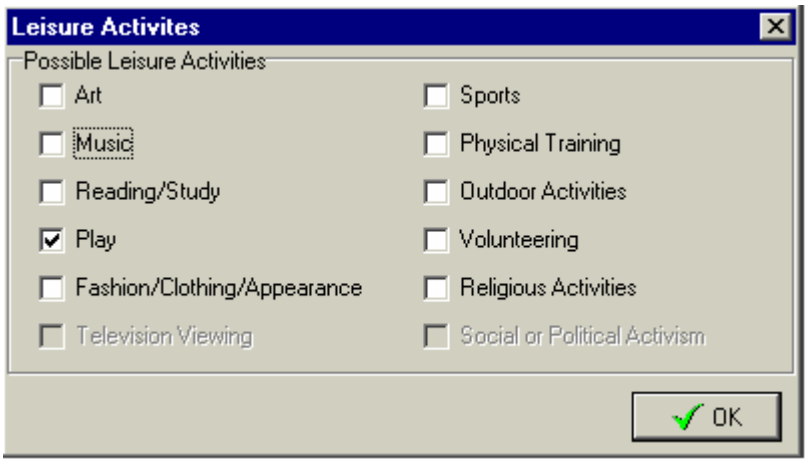


Move Out/Establish Household
This command allows the character to leave their family home and establish their own household. After this command is invoked, decisions about personal finances are made.

Change City of Residence
Use this command to change your city of residence within your country. There is no command to allow changing to other countries.

Change Dwelling
This command brings up the "Monthly Expenses" box. From this box, use the tab entitled "Housing" to change your residence.

Leisure Activities



Use this command to manually invoke the "Leisure Activities" menu. This menu is shown automatically during each simulation. However, by invoking it manually, you can control your leisure activities. Your selection of leisure activities affects the character's personal characteristics and the choices and opportunities your character will be offered during the simulation.

View Menu

Diary Window
Opens and closes the diary.

Family Window
Opens and closes the family matrix.

Personal Data Window
Opens and closes the personal data section.

Map Window
Opens and closes the map.

Help Menu

About
This contains information about Real Lives. Please refer to this section when you contact technical support.

User's Guide
Use this link to access the electronic User's Guide.

Chapter 4. Lesson Plans and Ideas

Your Real Lives package includes 4 complete lesson plans and numerous lesson ideas. Each lesson plan is aligned to National Education Standards and offers cross-curricular extension activities and assessment strategies. These powerful teaching, learning, and assessment resources are available by clicking the links that follow each description.

Each lesson plan is presented in two formats, Rich Text Format (RTF) and Adobe® Portable Document Format (PDF). You will also find printed copies in the Real Lives binder.

Lesson Plans

Lesson 1. Comparing Lives
This lesson plan gives students the experience of comparing their life with the life of a simulated character. Students learn about how other people live, and learn to use comparison techniques with the handout provided.

- Comparing Lives, RTF
- Comparing Lives, PDF
- Comparing Lives Handout, RTF
- Comparing Lives Handout, PDF

Lesson 2. Cause and Effect
This lesson plan helps students understand the relationship between cause and effect in the simulated lives they live. Causes explored include natural and man-made events and choices students make. Effects are wide ranging. Students learn to organize information, draw relationships between different data points and think critically as they use the tools provided to analyze their data.

- Cause and Effect, RTF
- Cause and Effect, PDF
- Cause and Effect Handout, RTF
- Cause and Effect Handout, PDF

Lesson 3. Journal
In this assignment, students will keep a journal of their simulated lives. Students step into the role of the simulated character, record events, research their surroundings and report on what they learn. This lesson plan is flexible and can be completed quickly or extended into a larger project that challenges students to apply more advanced research skills.

- Journal, RTF
- Journal, PDF
- Journal Handout, RTF
- Journal Handout, PDF
- Journal Assignment, RTF
- Journal Assignment, PDF

Lesson 4. ePALS
(Requires use of ePALS services. See http://www.epals.com for more information.)

This lesson plan requires the use of ePALS services. Using Real Lives, students live a life in another country. Then, using ePALS, your classroom is connected with a classroom in the country the students studied. Through this interaction, students confirm their Real Lives experiences and take a more detailed look at life in that country.

- ePALS, RTF
- ePALS, PDF
- ePALS Registration, RTF
- ePALS Registration, PDF

Lesson Ideas

In addition to the complete lesson plans provided, please see the following list of lesson ideas. Each idea can have one or more complete lesson plans developed around it to teach a variety of concepts.

- Lesson Ideas, RTF
- Lesson Ideas, PDF

Standards

Each lesson plan references national educational standards. The standards referenced are explained in this document.

- Standards Correlation, RTF
- Standards Correlation, PDF

Chapter 5. How to Get More Information

Educational Simulations is pleased to invite you to http://www.educationalsimulations.com, our public web site. There you will find additional lessons plans, a threaded discussion group (where you can communicate with other teachers using Real Lives), and instructions for contacting Educational Simulations with comments or questions about Real Lives or our charitable activities.

You may also call Educational Simulations at 888-832-1500 for technical support, customer service or for any other matter.